

Is it even worth doing something small for someone

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 1 myth · 8 sources · cheatgrid.com

The small thing that just crossed your mind is worth doing, by more than it looks from where you're standing. How small it seems to you tells you little about what it lands as for them.

THE GOAL

Do it now instead of holding out for something bigger. If it needs one quick step first, like grabbing or writing something, take that step today.

CHECKLIST

The instant a small, cheap way to help or treat someone crosses your mind and your first reaction is that it's too minor to bother with.

- ☐ If you can do the small thing right now with what's already in front of you, do it **before you talk yourself out of it**.
- ☐ If it needs one quick step first, like grabbing, buying, or writing something, do that step now instead of setting it aside for later.
- ☐ If the person isn't there right now, pick the exact time today you'll do it, not "later" or "sometime."
- ☐ Give it on its own, not folded quietly into something else you're already doing for them.
- ☐ Hand it over plainly, with no line like "it's probably nothing" or "sorry it's so small" attached.
- ☐ If you catch yourself shrinking it with a comment, **say what you noticed about them instead**, like "I saw this and thought of you."
- ☐ Give them a few seconds before reading their reaction, since a quiet or flat "thanks" isn't your answer.
- ☐ If you're still unsure it landed, ask them directly instead of guessing from how they reacted in the moment.
- ☐ Once it's given, let it stand. Don't add something bigger afterward to make up for its size.
- ☐ Write down, somewhere you'll actually see it again, that you did this today, so it's not just a thought that evaporated.
- ☐ Pick a line for next time, like "I saw this and thought of you," and say it out loud now so it's ready.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 You're not underrating a small gift because you don't care. You're worried it makes you look cheap.
- 2 Your own sense of how small something looks is **not a reliable measure** of what it will mean to them.
- 3 A gesture that costs you nothing can feel **just as good** to give as one that costs you something.

Where You're Guessing Wrong About Them

KNOW

You're not underrating a small gift because you don't care. You're worried it makes you look cheap. That worry keeps your attention on the object's quality, when what reaches them is the warmth it carries. [Source 1](#)

WATCH

Your own sense of how small something looks is **not a reliable measure** of what it will mean to them. Givers in a field test rated their own gesture near a 3 out of 10, and recipients rated the same gesture near a 7. [Source 1](#)

What The Size Isn't Deciding

KNOW

You don't need a bigger budget for it to count. In one study, giving away five dollars left people just as happy afterward as giving away twenty.

The amount people were given to spend on someone else made no difference to how happy it left them afterward. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

A gesture that costs you nothing can feel **just as good** to give as one that costs you something.

Toddlers in a study were just as happy giving away a treat they were simply handed as one from their own pile. [Source 3](#)

Why This Isn't As Rare Or Pointless As It Feels

KNOW

Doing something kind for someone else reliably lifts your mood. That held up the same way whether it was a small favor or something else, never just one particular kind of act.

The lift showed up the same way whether it was a small favor, spending money on someone, or another kind of kind act entirely. [Source 4](#)

KNOW

Helping with something small is not some above-and-beyond move. Across cultures, people asked for a bit of everyday help get a yes far more often than a no.

People in a study complied with small everyday requests about seven times as often as they said no or ignored them. [Source 5](#)

DO

Spend a bit of spare time, money, or attention on someone else instead of on yourself. It leaves you with **a sense of having mattered** that treating yourself doesn't.

People assigned to do something kind for someone else, rather than for themselves, reported feeling more capable and more like it meant something. [Source 6](#)

DO

Choose the warm version over the purely efficient choice when you can, even just a smile or a few words, instead of staying all-business.

People who had a brief, warm exchange with a stranger felt better afterward than people who kept the interaction purely efficient. [Source 7](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Giving someone something cheap makes them feel like you don't care as much as if you'd spent more.

ACTUALLY

Price isn't the signal. Across several studies, people's own reported appreciation **didn't move with the price** of what they were given, even though the people giving the gifts assumed it would. [Source 8](#)

Sources

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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Kindness and giving at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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